

Blades In Blue

— *Evan Li* —

Preview 1.0

Author's Notes

This is a preview of the manuscript I've been working on– roughly **50 pages**.

Prologue

– ??? | ??? –

He threw the jumbled thoughts down on the page before they fled his mind, never to return. *Remember, remember!* Domicer urged himself as the quill gently kissed the parchment.

Our way is collapsing, and its tales of chivalry and honor are coming to end. Oberath is becoming a realm of industrial witchcraft. The Emperor's Musketeers have hunted the King's noble warriors down to near annihilation. In a final effort to save the Commonwealth the King made an uneasy alliance with his great rivals from all corners of the kingdom, the great strength of all of the gods' men united under one wing. Many of us will not survive to return home, but even still in our people's hearts we will be immortal.

The wet ink had not yet dried when a wide prideful smile made it from corner to corner on Domicer's lips. He lifted the quill gently off the smooth waxy paper and looked up, and as the ink hardened into the pages Domicer felt his smile soften and dissolve.

Click. Clack. Click Clack. The sounds taunted him. The sparse hairs on his arms stood straight and his chest suddenly felt a bit heavy.

Who is that? What is she doing here? She's ruining it. Ruining it all. She is. Domicer almost accidentally complained about her out loud instead of in his head. Who would he even complain to?

Could he call the guards? They were ferociously elegant, dressed in pretty gold armor with bright blue cloaks and wielded their longswords and crossbows, standing firm, distantly in dark corridors. Each carried faces with scars and stared off into nothing. *Seasoned swords sworn to our liege.* He felt a sudden flash of courage, and his heart began to beat hard. *They protect me– I know this.* What noble men wouldn't?

Could he call the people? Well dressed and groomed lords and ladies, scholars and their sons, dukes and their daughters, laid sprawling across the floors. Young women climbing ladders to summit bookshelves, mothers holding their babes with one hand and their tomes in the other as they sat at their tables, fathers lecturing sons, pointing to maps and illustrations and texts, speaking of politics and tactics and trade and the like. *They adore me, I know.* And Domic did adore them, enough to stand between them and his most feared enemy. *Feared?* No, Domic did not fear.

Could he call his family? Domic's younger half-brother Kieran loved to read about the Witchhunters and the Beastslayers, he read next to Reese's old mason jar full of fireflies, the latter of which lit up the tables more than any of the lanterns. Back then, Reese would always take Kieran out to catch bugs, butterflies to let loose in the gardens, worms to throw in his terrariums, fireflies to keep out the monsters. He sat right next to Kieran, or laid, to be exact— reading about plants on his bed made of chairs. Those two would read for hours but would insist they were in those pages for days.

His mother watched the boys on the table's other side, a large shadow covering her face and body, leaving only her hands and fingertips easily visible. Across from her his sister Artemis stared at maps, her fingers resting gently against her temple.

My blood, they are here for me. I know. Yet Domic didn't dare speak. It was among all these walks of life that *she* stood out, out of place, out of the reaches of Domic's comprehension. No one dared regard the stranger girl. Maybe she wasn't there, maybe... Domic's mind was playing games with him *again*. What other explanation was there? She was an anomaly, an absurdity impossible to ignore yet everyone had been doing so flawlessly.

Others walked and were followed by the groaning and wailing of wooden boards, but as the *stranger* girl trotted along she was followed by the gentle playings of a percussionist slamming sticks into a block of wood. A scholar's cloak would play a rustle as they walked, a guard's armor played harsh clanks, the ladies jewelry played delicate tinkles, but *hers* played this mechanical jingle, like dangling bells on a key chain held by a twitching madman sewn into the linen of her cloak. And what a cloak it was.

A hooded wool tunic and a linen canvas meshed into one, rustic, almost like sandstone, only on it were the splatters from a palette of vibrant blasts of color that clung to the edges of her sleeves and sides of her collar. Under the cloak lay a wool sweater, with strangely uniform colorful dyed etches all over, resembling some sort of animal with tiny rubies for its red eyes that placed bumps on Domic's skin. Where the jingles played from the hanging strips stood a metal mouth, followed by a row of teeth. The *stranger girl* grabbed it and yanked it upward, devouring the fabric strip up to the opening of her neck, making a screaming ripping sound. Again, no one paid any mind to it, no one but Domic.

Her heels rose like ramps, her shoes long and tall and her legs had been sheathed in dark blue leather armor, strangely carrying all sorts of uniform seams and rivets. He could barely see her face. Somehow the shadows from the shelves had seemed to climb from her legs up her body and her clothes and her neck, only stopping to rest on her head. Her hair though, was clear to see.

Silky, long, and made of great waves that crashed against the shoals of her shoulder and flowed over them with a choppy elegance. The wave's water was sleek dark and blue, reflecting the night sky as it cascaded down to the ending strands where it splashed into vibrant streaks of violet cyan and indigo. As she got closer his mind and heart began to rail against him, punching his belly from the inside, ramming into the sides of his stomach, begging him to do something. He hardly could; his fingers felt frozen stiff and his bones felt as if they'd been burned hollow. But as stiff as he was, he was still a warrior, of courage and resolve. He inhaled and braced.

"Hell-Hello?" Domic almost slapped himself. What a courageous warrior he was. He cleared his throat and tightened his chest, though the fear was doing most of the tightening for him. "Who are you!?" He tried to sound brave, but his terror clung to his words as jitters. *I have to be brave like Artemis. Have to be? No, I am already brave, I always have been. I know, I know.* A giggle taunted him back. He swore he could see her open mouth and pearl white teeth in the shadows. He shuddered as the clacking and tapping got closer. *Is she coming for me?*

When she stepped closer for the last time, the candlelight on his desk shone onto her rosy cheeks and into her big eyes. Its embers danced around her hair like they were afraid of setting it ablaze. He said nothing, didn't dare move, only could barely muster to move his eyes and try to meet her face. Her eyes paired with her prismatic hair like the clouds did with the sunset, and like clouds, her irises were milky and misty. She had a sharp chin, smooth cheeks, and quaint wide lips. Her skin was smooth and porcelain, freshly polished, but carried a couple loose freckles around her upturned nose and its pinched nostrils. Those pupils of hers stared into him, peering through his eyes into the back of his mind where all his horrors cowered still. Soon after, those quaint wide lips opened.

"What are you wearing?" Her voice was smooth, sweet, and deeply curious.

What am I wearing? The rainbow fairy girl thinks he's the one who needs to explain his appearance. Had it been less amusing, he may not have played along. Domic wore his royal tunic, as he always did, carefully measured and tapered for his strong arms and broad shoulders. Shiny silver and platinum dotted him all over, from the caps on his shoulders and his elbows and near the gauntlets on his arm to the greaves on his legs, to the upper half of his cobalt-colored tunic. He gripped at the royal blues and pulled it forward for her to see, his leather shuffling as he did so. The fabric was soft spotless and fluffy like the fur coat of a cat.

"It's a tunic. The Sacrosanct wear it," he said proudly as if that wasn't common knowledge. She kneeled, looking down to inspect it.

"What's that symbol? Is that a unicorn?"

"A what?" She pressed her slender fingers against the emblem on his shirt. Her prismatic long nail shoved into Domic's chest. She pointed at the emblem ingrained on his tunic— a golden emblem of a horse and a sword pointing from the top of its head, ending right below where the mane began. It had two great golden gorgeous wings that spanned from one end of the garment to the other. "Oh! That's a pegasus. It's the Sacrosanct coat of arms" he proudly stated, puzzled by why she didn't recognize it. *She must have grown up under a rock.*

“The wings are golden... is that a metaphor?” She sounded like a child hearing a story about dragons for the first time. *Is she toying with me?*

“Who are you?!” Domic declared, sounding more angry than he meant. The chatter in the study had grown louder and louder, making the *stranger girl* harder and harder to hear. Among the chatter was the distant crashing of waves, they grew louder and louder as they crashed and crashed.

She paused, then let out a chuckle. “Right, I probably should have started with that. My name is Amelie, and I am a... how should I put it...”

“A Journeyman?” He jumped in, then immediately regretted not saying journeywoman instead. Was she one of the wandering traders who came to share exotic goods and tales before vanishing? *If she wants to vanish, now would be a great time.*

Amelie’s eyes lit up as she smiled, clearly impressed. “Yes! Kind of. More like a tourist.”

“A torest?” Now he felt like the one who grew up under a rock.

“It’s people who like to visit places I guess.”

I guess? She doesn’t even understand the words she’s saying. She was wasting time with a charade, Domic knew, but somehow he couldn’t stop himself. “So, you’re just here on an adventure then?”

She laughed, pulled out a chair close to him, and sat down. “Sure, I guess. I’m here for other things as well.”

“Such as?”

“Such as...” She took a second to ponder her answer. “I’m also a jailbreaker and an engineer.”

Engineer...? “What is an engineer?”

“It’s... like a builder.”

He stared at her awkwardly for a moment. “You’re also a jailbreaker? Are you going to help free our allies at Ashrend?” Domic spoke with a great deal of respect.

“Ashrend?”

“The fortress. It’s where they hold our people—hundreds of them. Maybe even thousands.”

“Not jails like that.”

“From army camps then?”

“No. From the prison of life.” She smiled and waved her hands around the air. “And all its boundaries.”

He looked at her in awe and horror for a moment. The waves loudly crashed in the distance. “Do you take lives? Is that what you are saying?” His muscles began to tense up. He could feel his jittering right hand move closer and closer to the pommel of his sword.

She chuckled. “Whoa, I didn’t say that. Life has different dimensions. Different forms. Different ways of representing itself. Isn’t that remarkable? We are just flesh, yet we can see and think and imagine. We have aspirations, passions, perceptions, and journeys. Yet we don’t see other lives as so. We confine them to the land they were born, the people who surround them, the bodies they are born with, the personalities we expect them to have. I’m a prison breaker, but I break people out of the confines of our lives.”

“Whats outside our lives?”

“Crowns.” She smirked. “We could all be kings and queens. There is a world where you are a king. Where you met the right people, was told the right things, got lucky at the right times. Yet right now, you are not one. Is it because you lack kingliness? Or because this world lacks a throne worthy of you?”

Maybe there are those worlds, and maybe that's why no one's heard of them. “I break people from the confines of their lives, but not like you.” Domic said reluctantly as he looked down. The armor on his shoulders, mail on his arms, gloves on his hands, each felt heavier and tighter by the second, and his skin started to get warm and sticky. His scabbard began to feel heavy on his hip, as if it were filled with seawater around his sword. The smell of salt went up his nose.

“So... who are you? You have to tell, since I answered first.” She said very nervously, before she chuckled and grabbed the book from his desk. She read it out loud in a mocking tone. Domic hid his rosy face before he snatched it back. She got as far as ‘Many of us will not survive to return home’. There was a sudden frown on her face. He frowned with her, for some odd reason.

“Don’t be sad.” He said with a small smile. “We’re not afraid of death.”

She looked shocked. “Why?”

“I’m not a coward.” Domic said duly. “To die for the greater good, it’s no easy thing but... any real man would do it.”

“How do you know?”

He looked back for a moment. “That it will be for the greater good?” She nodded. “I suppose I just need to have hope.”

“Hope? You’re going to potentially give up your life, which is all you have, and you’re just going to hope it amounts to something?”

“I suppose so.” He wore a smile with pride. “But our hope isn’t blind or stupid, it separates us from our enemies.”

“What will you be after?” She asked, bright sparks from candlelight danced in her pupils as she did so. “If you don’t die for the greater good of course.”

“After...” He sighed. “After we win? I never really thought about it. It’s hard to think I’d ever see the end of it I suppose.”

“So... you hope that your death will have great meaning, but you don’t hope that you won’t die at all?” She gave a concerned chuckle. “You should go charging into the battle hoping to return to the ones you love!”

Battle... The waves slammed into the doors outside. “The battle... how do you know about that?” He stared at her. “Are you spying on me!?”

She laughed. “What is there to even spy on? You’re just moping at your desk like an emo.” She coughed into her hand. “I meant... you just don’t seem to be doing much that’s worth spying on.”

He scoffed. “We’re soon to embark on a great battle. Not that you would know. You don’t even know the king’s coat of arms.” Water began to get well in his eyes.

“You’re *about to*? I thought you were writing. When is this battle?”

“It’s in...” Domic eyes dropped a bit. His mind searched and reached but found nothing. Suddenly, he felt faint and dizzy. *It’s soon, no, it was...* “Wait. I’m confused.” His voice cracked a little.

“Alright...” She seemed discontent and unsatisfied. She looks at him. “What are you doing? Right now?” Her eyes grew skinnier; her brows sunk down.

He cautiously looked back, before nervously gripping the table’s edges. “I’m here to enjoy time with my family and people and my comrades?” His voice grew shaky and unsure. *What does she want from me? She can’t do anything here. No one can. I know.*

She looked concerned, scared for him even. It made Domic feel uneasy. “Why are you actually here? You can tell me!” She urged gently but firmly. “I don’t want to scare you but you have to stop lying to *me*.” He glared back. His nails began to mine shavings from the tabletop as they ground down and back and forth upon it. “Why are you actually here?”

Lying? Me? Domic does't lie. Telling the truth had cost him far more than a scolding before, and it hadn't stopped him then. "I don't have to entertain you. Is there a reason you've come here to chastise me!?" A tear fell into his mouth as it opened and closed. *Salty*. His hands trembled. "I'll have the guards remove you. *I will*." He hissed. "*I will and—*" He raised his hand to call them over, but she snatched it down. Her smooth skin soothed his nerves, as did the rainbow daggers that were her nails, colorful blades leaving trails of red as they slid down his forearm to his elbow. The trails of red were quick to harden and turn sickly pale before slowly regaining their healthy color. He wanted to nudge but she said something that turned his bones to stone.

"What's the last thing you remember?" While her nails acted as daggers on his skin, his continued acting like pickaxes and shovels as they dug into the grounds around them— the palms of his hands and the caps of his knees, the sharp tingles and jolts rocking Domic's limbs. He wanted to curse them, only he knew that the sensations were one of the few things that kept him there and whole. His throat tightened and the air grew thick and coarse.

"Wait, I'm confused." He lamented between gasps. That woman— *Amelie*. She looked disconcerted and uncertain. The waves crashed.

"The last thing." She begged. "Before you spoke to me, before you wrote in that book, before you came here, *what were you doing?*" She cried for answers.

The interrogation had Domic shaking as he could only answer in "uhms" and "uhs" until he heard the waves from the beaches crashing again against the study hall doors and saw the water and seaweed slowly crawl out through under them. "Water." Domic declared. *I can taste salt on my tongue. I can feel it seep into my wounds. My body feels on fire.*

"So, you remember water?" She looked extremely concerned, yet curious. "Water, okay. Were you in the water?"

"... Yes" His voice began to break, and his right leg started jittering and bouncing up and down. The nails had mined ores of blood. Even the table was trembling now.

“Okay, what were you doing in the water?” The doors slowly nudged open as more water began to flood in, along with urchins, shells, weeds, and the like.

“I was... I was drowning. I think I’m dying.” He spoke in terrified upset whispers, his leg bouncing fast enough to shake the floor but no one seemed to notice. His head dropped and hung down. “This might be it.” His voice sank with each word. The water turned red as it rose, climbing higher and higher and growing darker and darker. Crimson waves filled with sand and salt splashed all over the shelves and the people, soaking the tomes and their pages and the people and their robes. They did not notice.

“Listen, look at me.” She said again. “You’re still here. You’re still able to talk to me. You can think and dream and wish.” Domeric didn’t respond, he just nodded. She sat on top of the table, getting closer, as her voice became soft and cheery. “That means you’re still alive. Not just surviving, but you’re alive! I told you before. Life is more than just air and water and meat. But only if you acknowledge it. As long as you are you, as long as you have whims and wishes that the world can’t convince you aren’t real... there’s still hope. You understand?”

“You have to wake up!” His chest grew tighter and tighter. He could barely breathe. “Wake up!”

I know. Wake up, I know. I know.

Suddenly, a great boom parted the waves in the study, forming a funnel that took the books out from their shelves in a whirlwind. The doors had burst open. There a boy stood, an image of Domic, in all his vicious grace. His head was smoldering, only the smoke was ink black and disheveled and fell downwards over the sides of his face, condensing into long silky strands. Obscured amidst the shadow, he could make out an eye— a goblet of wine, down to the hue of its color, down to the deepness of its red ring, and down to the glimmer of luster in an odd corner. The other of his was gone, lost to the darkness. In place of a blue tunic and metal armor he donned dark black furs laid over red leather and garments of bone strapped with crude rope sparsely covering his body, the rest was left exposed save for his red trousers and black leather straps that criss-crossed all over. On his pale ghastly pale skin were scars of red ink, blood-like tattoos that resembled daggers and blades and crosses that followed his arms and waistline, accompanied by the many red veins in his lanky arms and legs, all stripped bare of fat leaving only wiry muscle. He held in one hand not a longsword but a blade with teeth like those on Amelie's jacket— only instead of shiny gray metal his was dark red and black with the red dripping off.

Where his abdomen lay half a dozen gashes, each making a blue spotlight where blades broke his skin. They were deep and gaping, massive holes in the walls of his stomach and chest, shooting deep blue beams, and soon after seawater poured out of them and onto the ground below.

“UP!” He heard her voice again.

Domic's eyes shut. *I'm awake. I know, I know.* Then they opened.

Domeric Raimes I

– *Bladeslinger* | *Oberath* –

A dark red abyss where only the faint silhouettes of fish feasting on corpses gave him company. *Have I died and gone to hell?* Juices drained from his eyes and strength from his limbs and air from his lungs. Besides the fish gracefully swam the shadows of arrows with triangles for heads and v's for tails, some of them dragged great crimson clouds behind them before they too were swallowed by the sea. From far away he heard what sounded like a drawbridge being raised over and over and over, a grinding gear making *thump, thump, thump* sounds. Domeric almost mistook it for his own heart.

Everything was heavy and crushing. Domeric's chest felt tight and empty. His head was pounding and his limbs were weak. As his lungs began to empty the color started to drain from his vision. *Hell. I am in hell*, he thought as everything got darker. Amelie had been too late and now he was a drowned corpse in a bath of raspberry salt, doomed to be crushed under the weight of the oceans and gasping for air till the end of time and to be feasted on by fish. Then he saw it. A massive curved shadow looming above him like a small black sun, he could scarcely make out its sails, wings, and rudder. *The Cladwing*– the great pride of the royal fleet– swam with the elegance of a golden siren. The King's craftsmen worked tirelessly to make the most nimble, graceful and mighty ship his liege had ever seen, with flapping golden wings, royal blue sails, and a great big waterwheel in the back that churned water into a white froth. As he gazed upon it, a sudden wave of pride crashed into him, drenching his legs and fingertips with strength and vigor. *We are the sons of Maverick.*

But, however tirelessly the king's craftsmen had worked, the Wychen had worked harder still. No feat of naval carpentry can change what their bolts did to the ship's boards. They flew in a barrage from the sky. The sails went first, the shadow of the falling mast loomed over the water. Next went the deck, the wooden boards exploding into splinters. The hull followed, and soon enough, the ship was a ship no longer. He could see shadowy figures clamor and jump overboard as she was shredded to gibs. His heart sank harder and he wished to sink with it, all the way to the sealake floor. Boys flew overboard-- the ones that didn't get cut in half by the bolts-- and he could see them flailing in the water and hear them screaming in his head, the sapphire banners fell and sank, and with it the royal insignia of the flying holy horse. The finest vessel designed in the Commonwealth chopped to pieces by some turret. Domic made a small whimper in the water as he watched. Suddenly, the cold dread burned into hot rage, and he began to rise as fast as the bubbles that came steaming out of his nose up to the water's surface. Domic was wrong; he wasn't in hell, he was below it, frozen stiff watching everyone else burn. If the battlefield was hell, then the devils would be there, and Domic couldn't stand idly by as they basked the world in flame. His arms and legs flailed like a dying fish, the sealake's surface came closer and closer to slamming him in the face. He was almost there but his vision began to go black. His arms stopped feeling like limbs and more like sticks strapped to his body. His mind began to go away, and all he could think about was the dream. *Up, up!*

His head punched through the surface of the water, his mouth as wide as a whale's, the air rushing through his veins, bringing color back to his vision and thoughts back into his mind. *I could take that breath of air for eternity*, he thought. He looked around-- arrows still flew, young corpses littered the water's surface like lilies, with their boyish hair for pink flowers and empty bodies for the pads. Huge explosions appeared in the water as boulders rained from above, and anybody caught in the explosions turned to red mist. The horrified crew of the destroyed ship screamed, some of them swimming downwards to face drowning instead of the bolts and boulders. Domic would not join them. *I will never go down again, only up*. Up to *Ashrend*, its great ballistas and spires looming above in the distance.

It would take more than a few destroyed ships to stop the King's sons. They would seize the fortress. They would kill the Artificer and hang his head on the walls along with the Commonwealth's banners. He thought of the Wychen, all comfortable and plump and fat and warm in the halls that they stole. *Those men will reap.* Calling them men was a stretch. They were filthy demonic beasts wearing the skin of men, with no qualms of murdering and enslaving their way across the world. Those *creatures* have nothing to offer this anyone—not valiance nor righteousness—only greed, appetites, and low cunning. Everything they touched turned to shit and nothing better proves that point than Castle Ashrend itself. The former hunting outpost and commerce center had once been the Chasseur's pride and cultural hub, armed to the teeth with weapons and mounted turrets, filled with butcher shops. Domic's siblings would often visit with the Duke, while Domic admired the bustling sounds of street stalls and the beauty of the tall black brick walls. Now, they say brave warriors are paraded in the halls like cattle. Domic would throw them out, he swore, to every god there was and will be. He swam, now with air in his lungs and blood back in his veins, he powered through the water like a shark.

The water crashed against his head. *That girl's hair...* That was just a dream, but a mad part of him believed he had a vision. The King's grandfather Horen had a vision of uniting all of Oberath under the Commonwealth when he was just a boy, and that vision had dictated the future since.

Have I gone mad? Important people have visions. A blessing from the goddess perhaps? *Have I served well enough? Did she reach her hand out to me?* Domic had to have lived for a reason, he decided. He flopped onto the black clay bank that buffered the black hundred-foot castle walls from the red water. Some parts of the clay kept souvenirs—fallen blades, burnt pieces of leather, fragments of skull— all lay under the bank half covered like seashells on a beach.

The wall rode atop a massive black cliffside, its terracotta edges crumbling bit by bit from the pounding of war. From the wall's parapets came small blasts of smoke along with sharp cracks and booms that rang out. Something whizzed near Domic, finding the clay near him and shooting a plume of black clay out of the ground like a geyser. Domic looked down to see a few panicked soldiers, some in gold and blue armor, others in black and red furs, some young and pale, others old and bloody. He stared blankly before one of their chests exploded and spat out red vomit before falling into the clay, the other soldiers and Domic instantly hit the ground. His training had kicked in, but even so, his heart was booming and his fingers shook like a boat in the storm. Domic scanned the field for his comrades while the ground was booming with gunshots. He saw the ballistas spitting into the sea, the spiders crawling over the watchtower roofs, but not the 32nd battalion.

"Captain!? Anyone!?" Domic cried out as he lay on the sand, but the only response he heard was the beating gears of crossbow turrets and the sounds of boulders slamming against the clay and waters. *Thump thump thump*. Each loud sound made him jolt out of fear— the fear that he would die before even getting to fight the enemy, before he would even see an enemy. *I will not die with a clean blade*. He staggered his way through the beach's graveyard, walking with a strange frustrated shock. He forced his dry lips open. "CAPTAIN!? CAN YOU HEAR ME?" His head was pounding, as was his heart. The red sun was gorgeous but blinding, it ripped the clouds ahead in two to glare straight into his eyes. *Thump thump thump*.

The next time he tried to shout no words came out, only a cocktail of blood and seawater that he nastily spit out onto the clay. He staggered forward, vision doubled and legs almost buckling under the weight of his weapons. He saw a helmet in the distance, the metal shell had a luster of silver and a plume of blue, with an open visor and dagger blue eyes that could be made out even from this distance. The captain was crowded around by other boys, most of whom were shorter with cheaper gear. Domic felt his chest loosen as he took a great exhale. He should have called out, but instead just wandered closer, the distant unintelligible talking drawing him. He wanted so badly to hear someone's voice— not screams or barked orders for once.

“You hear the gears on those things?” The Captain with the blue plume cried, half in frustration and half in awe. “They’re so... *smooth*. I think that’s more than thirty shots with no pause, no delay, not even a squeak from its cogs. Our’s can’t even go two shots without sounding like a dying horse.” *Captain Tavick*. Domic smiled. His mentor stood tall and staunch, with a full frame and weary skin. He seemed well kept, mostly shaven save a slight stubble and donned a shiny clean suit of armor, but his eyes told a different story– the weariness of war had gotten to him. *It’s clearly getting to him at this moment*. “I can’t wait to kill the bastard who mans that gun.”

“You have to hand it to this Artificer. I’ve never seen craftsmanship like this before.” A second knight responded, clad in chainmail with a blue cloak draped over his body. Eidrick stood with the same height as Tavick but with far worse presentation. His beard and hair were overgrown, and his face wore numerous scars. While Tavick’s eyes held a hint of weariness, Eidrick’s made it clear he hadn’t slept for weeks. “They think we can beat this with a few fancy ships and a bunch of barbarians?” *Barbarian*. Domic nearly flinched, even though he had heard it a thousand times. “What the hell was high command thinking?” Eidrick continued. Domic was less pleased to see him than his captain.

The opposite could be said when Domic caught a glint of the shaggy birdnest that was Kieran’s hair, as well as his overly long and loose fitting black furs and endearing looking blood tattoos. Most Bladeslingers like knives and bones and skulls and arrows on their skin, but Kieran’s made a beautiful vine with fruit and roses that climbed his torso. He sat there, looking lost as always with an awkward face and big upturned nose. Kieran did not speak to the others often, as opposed to his buddy beside him, who taunted Eidrick with his scoffing.

“It comes down to the swordsman, not the sword, otherwise we should all just pick up smithing for the cause instead.” Domicer recognized Hadrian from all the way from when he first set his eyes on the 32nd from how narrow his torso and obliques were. His tattoos were all crows and wine, his hair was long, loose, wavy and soft, and fell exactly where he wanted on each part of his face. He was short and skinny, though with shapely muscles, with small vibrant red freckles around his upturned nose. Hadrian got on Eidrick’s nerves but it made no matter– Hadrian could spit on the fiercest soldier in Oberath and they would do nothing about it, unless they didn’t know him well. *He’s very good looking until he opens his mouth.* “Besides, don’t give the Artificer all the credit, his engineers do most of the work.”

“Edge-in-nears?” Eidrick scoffed. “Did you hit your head when the ship crashed?” He spoke to the other two Sacrosanct Lumiknights, Mathis Baker and Leylo Baker, scanning for their laughs. The short and stocky pair had shed most of their armor. Mathis stared off into the distance watching the ships get destroyed in the distance, his mouth was agape. A massive black-eye seemed to have found its way on his face after the crash. Leylo sat on the ground frozen and unmoving. They had both watched Mertos get blasted to bits by the ballistas when their ship, *the Ladylome*, was torn in two.

“Engineers.” Domicer harshly whispered as he corrected him. The cogs in his head turned like those on the ballistas. *A vision. I knew it. No, I’m mad...* Tavick made a yelp sound that would have been funny under different circumstances. Kieran and Eidrick whipped around.

“You were here the whole fucking time?” Hadrian asked. Tavick let out a sigh of relief and gave him a hug. Kieran ran up as well, wrapping his arms tightly around Domicer’s chest.

“We thought the worst. Do you know how hard we were looking for you?” Tavick barked.

“No.”

“Thank god!” Tavick laughed like a drunk old man. Domic punched him on the shoulder jokingly before blowing on his knuckles, forgetting how tough Tavick’s armor was. That made him laugh harder, he roared like a lion. *It’s not that funny.* “You’ve heard the word before, no? *Engineers*” He mocked his voice in a brooding tone. “You sound like you have.”

“Why do you care,” Domic said.

“I’m curious.” He shrugged. “We might die here so I may as well find out while I still can.”

“Who’s ‘we’?” Hadrian asked. Eidrick told him to shut up for Domic.

“I don’t remember.” Domic lied to Tavick. *Am I supposed to say I dreamt of it?* The absurdity briefly washed over his mind before he opened his mouth. “What’s our next move?” Domic’s hands were shaky, and his breath grew restless. “Why are you all just waiting here?”

“I don’t know! What are we waiting for?” Hadrian tested the Captain’s patience. “Let’s just go in.”

“No.” Tavick spoke sternly. Domic looked closely at the wall that towered over them. Ink black burn marks dotted the walls for when the Lumiknights shot their firework barrages to try to screen the ships from the turrets and Musketeers. The smell of powder from their barrels clung to the air with the blood, salt, sweat and clay. Domic’s battalion hugged the wall close, but the Wythen Musketeer’s plumes of smoke could still be seen as they turned into clouds and drifted freely off into the sky. In the distance, he could see shadows run up to where the drawbridge once was and fire shots up at the wall before collapsing into the ground. “We’re waiting for the next barrage?” He said solemnly.

“That’s right. We just learned the hard way that even when the fireworks splatter over all the turrets they can still see– not sure how. Blinds the Musketeers at least. Either way, whether the rest of the Regiment realizes it or not, the plan is set. First barrage for the ships. Second barrage is for when we charge through the gate. Each wave is timed with the barrage.”

Domeric stared at Tavick, stared at how Hadrian and Kieran's hands hovered around their rappel hooks, and how the whole company had crowded themselves around this random segment of the wall. "We're not joining them? Are we cowards!?"

Eidrick laughed. "Fuck no! I like breathing."

"That's right Dom-- well, not the coward part. If we can't rely on the fireworks, we'll need some other distraction." Tavick gave the boy an impressed smile.

"You're going to leave them to die, use them as a distraction to sneak into the fortress? What of our brothers? What of honor?" *What kind of knight are you?* He heard himself say in his head but not out loud.

Tavick's huge smile dissolved. "It seems unchivalrous, I know, but it's our best chance. I wish the command saw this coming, but it's too late."

"Don't be so dumb, *Dom*. They're charging the turrets, with or without us." Hadrian pointed out in the most pretentious way possible. "You always praise the king so much. He wants the fortress back. A true loyal servant of his would be willing to forsake his courage for a brief moment if it meant raising the odds of victory."

"He's right..." Kieran agreed. "Dom, they would want us to. If we can sneak over, we will have a better chance." Domeric contemplated. *Do we truly have to be so slimy?*

"Sorry lad. It wouldn't matter if you wanted to or not-- I already ordered. Now you must follow." He spoke, bluntly honest. *Yes sir*, Domeric said in his head with sarcastic enthusiasm before putting his hands around the rope and beginning to spin it in a small circle. It rang loud crisp wispy sounds in the air as he handled the steel string, and soon enough Hadrian and Kieran joined the band.

“Remember, everyone!” Tavick yelled. “If you find a man with half his face missing, you grab him on the spot! The Artificer responsible for the deaths of thousands of people, and is the cog of the Wychen War Machine! We will break into his fortress, seize him, and spill his secrets. No kingdom has ever had their inventions flourish so fast. The Royal command insists they have some sort of trick, and that trick is within our former fortress!”

Domeric clenched his teeth as he closed in on the wall. What sort of barbarities exist in the Artificer’s playhouse? What sort of horrible rituals had he performed to bless his empire with such power? He did not want to see at all. *Soldiers, innocents, even children have to see it, endure it. If they can, I have to.* “I can skate up there no problem. It would be faster.” Hadrian cocked a bolt in the side of his boot, the sound made the hairs on Domeric’s arm stand straight. The first time he tried blade-skating was on his village’s rooftops with Kieran and Artemis. He slipped on a bird’s nest, tumbled onto the brick roof of the Armory, breaking his ankle when he landed before sliding off and falling onto the street below.

“I don’t think that’s a good idea.” Kieran said bluntly. “That wall is nearly fifty feet high, we should save our energy.” Kieran was right of course, but part of it might have been to save Domeric the embarrassment. The whistling began. *The fireworks.* A huge flash of white could be seen over and above his head, though he kept his eyes to the ground. A huge blast erupted behind them where a boulder became part of the ground, showering them with black clay. Domeric and Kieran jolted as Hadrian carelessly flung the black clay off his black hair before throwing the hook upwards where it dangled and snatched onto the side of the parapet. Domeric and his brother followed suit, waiting to hear the metal clink against the stone and giving the rope three test pulls before grabbing tight. The firework’s whistling grew louder as they approached from the ships’ cannons– the ones that were left at least. He placed his feet flat against the black brick and soon enough the wall had become the ground, and the ground the wall. The rope tensed and made weak groans, and the trio began to walk. He could barely make out the small silver caps in the distance, who were taking potshots at the boys who were still making it out of the water.

The winds began to blow, they howled in his ear relentlessly. Domic thought of the Musketeers at the top of the wall, and their massive guns and big axes. *If they look down...* Domic would be a massive fish in a tiny barrel. He looked down at his Sacrosanct comrades, all waiting carefully in their silver armor, crossbows loaded. *Can Tavick shoot them before they shoot me?* The rope creaked. He stepped, and the leather bottom of his boot slipped a little, and Domic thought for half a heartbeat that he fell off the wall and smacked the ground, where his bones would break in one great snap. He would be a mangled mess in front of them all. *What if it snaps and I fall? Would they laugh? Would they just sigh and shake their heads? Will they know it's not my fault?*

Domic imagined the crack of the barrel and the jolt of his body, of him dangling lifelessly like a fool in front of all his friends and foes. The purple gray hands, the blue white hands, the red pale ones, they all pointed and laughed. *Laughing at me.* His chest was tight, his ribcage felt as if it was collapsing on itself. *What if they shoot me in my eyes? Mother loves my eyes...* He could hear the breathing in his ears, and it drowned out the screams of horror and the sounds of gunfire. His hands shook and his legs were vibrating. He was half breathing, he felt no air in his tight lungs but could hear his panting over Kieran, who was screaming something. Kieran was above him now, him and Hadrian. *Did I stop walking?* Domic looked down again. His battalion had turned into ants way below, and suddenly he felt a huge breeze against his sides. His hands were slippery. The rope creaked. *Creak, creak.* Kieran was screaming more, he could see Hadrian's mouth open and close.

'dom.'

I must be brave and strong, like Tavick, like Artemis.

Kieran was shouting but Domic did not hear, only saw his mouth opening and closing as they were strung on the rock wall, like climbers, back when brother Reese would bring them with cables to scale the Render cliffsides. It filled him with joy, and with joy came pride.

I am a king's son, a cherished son of the Gods. Courage is my duty. It felt like his head was being pinched. He imagined whole crowds cheering for him now.

They're chanting for me to do it. I have to. “Domic!” Kieran's eyes grew big and watery and pleaded with him. “Please Domic, we can do this! We have to go up!”

Up, up! Domic heard the girl's voice still in his head, along with the jingles of her metal and the clicking of her boots. *I will never go down again.* He said that, hadn't he? *I will never go down, only up.* Domic's hands tightened around the rope. He moved one foot after another.

Karina Kenning I

– *Dark Arts Academy* | *Oberath* –

She always thought lowly of those who listened to gossip. Of course, she herself did all the time, but it was different for her– the others always would hear a mutation of a mutation corrupted by envy and arrogance and hope, and think it pure. Karina was a better listener than that.

But it was more observing than listening– observing arrogance in their smiles, or admiration in the eyes. Their gullibility, their delusions, their favors and peeves, their presumptions about how the world actually worked. She should thank them, for the only honest things they end up saying are about themselves.

“They say his mind works differently– that I heard he can see colors others can’t, imagine events days before they occur!” One of them chanted in awe and wonder, an enthusiastic young boy with big dumb eyes that fit well with his pretentious scholar uniform. “It gives him military and political genius.”

“That’s a given.” A Musketeer answered, thankfully interrupting the boy before he broke into song. He had toned muscles, a bushy beard, and a handsome young face. He wore illustrious and shiny purple armor, with jagged edges all over, perfectly highlighting the bulges around his arms and shoulders. A musket with a barrel the size of a small spear and an obsidian dual sided axe lay strapped to his back. *Lavender Crystalmail. Must be rich... handsome as well.* She already despised him. “But it’s not truly his vision that makes him so great, it’s his might.” He droned on. “His prowess in battle is uncontested. When the Pirate King rampaged the Fissures, it was Karrow who buried a spear in his chest! They say he fought with the strength of a thousand men!” The gods always loved to waste good cheekbones and pretty eyes on morons.

“You’re both wrong.” A shrewd old man answered, gray haired and bearded. This one wore no mail, instead donning a dusty captain’s uniform, and while the Musketeer’s armor did well to accentuate his biceps and shoulders the captain’s uniform did the same for his beer belly and love handles. “It’s neither about strength nor intellect. You wish to know the real reason? It’s because he is *ruthless*. His father was strong and shrewd too, yet it did not matter for when the heretics rose up against him he did not show the makings of an emperor.”

“Blasphemy, you old lunatic!” The young dreamer spat. “The Late Shade Emperor displayed nothing but wisdom and virtue, just like his heir.”

The old man grew louder. “You call it wisdom to treat with your enemies and let them slaughter you in your own halls? I call it a lack of conviction! It’s time we pay the heathens back in kind– under a decisive, ruthless leader.” The old man had a point, she agreed, but to what degree? The Shade Emperor, in the wake of his fathers murder at the hands of the Sacrosanct delegates, had waged a destructive war that had united all of Oberath against the Wychen people for the sake of conquest. No matter how powerful they were, they were outnumbered three to one.

“I wouldn’t expect anything less of my liege. He destroys any opposition.” The templar said in agreement.

The yapping eye candy was of no interest to her, nor the old glutton, nor the up-jumped poet. It was only earned by the mass of muscle bundled up in the corner, like links of white sausage rolled into a massive mess with oily strands of silver hair holding it all together, laying sprawling around the chunks of meat. She couldn’t avert her gaze, so she called for him like a songbird. “*You sir.*” Her voice was full of wonder and intrigue. “What do *you* believe?”

“Believe about what?” He spoke cranky and reluctant, as if he knew the entire conversation ahead of time and was weary to repeat it. Karina would not tolerate it– some gloomy sod acting like she was dull.

“About his liege! Of course!” She acted excited to talk about it, as if the Emperor’s mere title was going to make her kick her feet and giggle.

“His liege...” The sunken man began to rise. The candidates all stared. There were fang marks all over him, on his shoulders and near his ribcage. The mark of a hand lay on his right cheek, his face looked clammy and his lips were so cracked bits of skin fell off as he spoke. He exhaled like a dying mule, wheezing as he spoke with malice and hatred, spitting venom to his audience. “His liege is-” He quickly lowered his voice as he could hear the rest of the guards marching, their rhythmic steps shaking and rumbling the whole floor as the storm approached. “His liege is *mad*. Totally crazed, insane, and delusional. He kills not with strength but with the arcane, the product of centuries of toiling and unnatural experimentations. He is all that is cruel and unholy in this world. He is ungodly— no, he is the soul of a demon himself wrapped in skin.

“How dare you!” The young boy’s voice cracked as he screamed in protest. Karina was proud of herself for not chuckling out loud. “You’re the only mad man present in this castle!” *Also, the only man*, Karina added in her head.

“Palace.” The Musketeer corrected him. A telling correction of course— palace was a much more praiseworthy title than castle, it had prettier decorations after all. What more could she expect, of course *he* would only care about *that*. He stared down the sunken stranger with his dagger diamond eyes. “In what hell would you know? I will not tolerate this nobody to make snides about his liege.” His fingers fumbled around his musket’s handle, before hoisting it up and aiming it with a remarkable form that the military community has been tragically unaware of.

“Nor will I.” The fat captain rose to his feet as well, drawing an iridium sword as he did so. It was a family heirloom— old, fancy, strong as a needle, sharp as his chins. “Speak more slander and I’ll hack you to pieces” *With that? Is he a cheese?* Maybe they would all kill each other and she would go home with a promotion. She smiled at the thought.

“Hack at me will you?” The strongman mocked as he towered over all of them.

“Should you continue making problems!” the Gunknight said in a sugar sweet voice, trying to hide his shaking.

“I’m making no problems boy, but if you want to start, the Emperor’s going to need some servants to wipe down this room.” He snarled, before being interrupted by a booming shout that bounced off the walls and ceiling alike.

“Hail Karrow!” A man in purple armor clicked his heels and slammed his musket butt into the ground, the wood making a clunky echo in the hall. Half a dozen guards came in double file, then spread apart in unison. *Now those are marksmen. Maybe one of them should audition.*

“HAIL Karrow!” Everyone in the room, save the sunken man shouted at the same time. His liege did not notice the one absent cheer, for his state was perplexingly offputting and dismal. A walking soup of alcohol and elixirs and potions, and he smelled of it too— old burned herbs, tar, fermented grains, and aged sap. The air around him was sticky. Clacks against the floor sounded out as the Emperor used a stick with an amethyst at its head to help him walk. He drooled where he went, it glowed purple and bounced on the ground a few times before solidifying. His skin was gross and patchy, and extremely loose. It reminded her of a peach left out in the sun too long, and a deeply disturbed part of her wanted to pick it off, only she knew under it wasn’t warm sweet nectar but some concoction of sorcery, gluttony, extravagance, and the damnation from gods. His purple cloak poorly drooped over his hunch back, doing a poor job at fitting his body.

“What are we doing here?” Karrow asked. “Why are these strangers in my room? Deal with them you lunatics!”

“My liege, those are the candidates you chose.” The most senior guard answered.

“I... chose?” His eyes were slightly bloodshot. He looked confused and angry. “For what, an afternoon picnic?” He panted as he spoke.

“No my liege, for...” The guard sighed and leaned down slightly, and lowered his tone in a quieter but still distinct volume. “For case green.”

The king suddenly jolted his head upwards. “Shut up!” He smacked the man on his head, his fist denting it and hitting the soldier on his dome, making a comical *bonk* sound. The guard yelped in pain and staggered backwards. “Why the hells are you speaking of it here, you fucking fool? You want them all to know about it? Did you all hear?” The king asked the applicants.

“We did, sir!” The loyal dreamer volunteered before she could say anything. *Fuck. I hope he gets killed first.* Now the king knew, and he had reason to put their heads on spikes. Hopefully her head gets to go next to the pretty man instead of the fatass or the huge freak.

“Sir? Sir!? SIR!?” The king spat out, so outraged he choked on his spit a little. “The next time you address me, you will say *my liege*.” He said with disgust. “Understand!? Have you no respect for prestige or royalty?”

“No, no, no my liege!”

“No? Are you moronic? Are you simple?”

“No my liege!” he profusely apologized.

“No? Then you’re not wary of our customs since you are not one of us! Can you believe this men?” The king shouted. “A traitor among us in disguise! Dispatch him now!” The sounds of guns clicking made the boy almost fall to his knees and start crying.

“No my liege, I am so sorry my liege.” The scholar begged. “I just wished to serve you my liege, I got carried away my liege, please.”

“Alright then, serve. Answer me, are you a sacrosanct in disguise?”

“No sir, not at all!” he cried out.

“Prove it. You’re a scholar right?”

He straightened his voice. “Yes my liege.”

“In what?”

“In history and military strategy, my liege.”

“History then, huh? What fish populate River Nox?”

“I-I don’t know that!” the boy proclaimed. “I study history and military?”

“Fish are important to our culture, our cuisine, our trade!” He carelessly gestured his arm in the air before sighing. “Fair enough, history is it? What fish dominated the river 200 years ago?”

“I don’t know!”

Suddenly, a flash of darkness erupted from the amethyst-stick, and the boy suddenly was reduced to his screaming shadow on the wall when the purple mist cleared. The black shadow was permanently etched into the wall, no matter which way the light shone. Where the boy was, a small pile of ashes now lay. The applicants besides her and the hulking man gasped and stepped back. The guards all made a face. *Just another evening for them.* The Musketeer and the Captain both looked a bit pale and their fingers began to shake. Karina's were perfectly still.

"Ha! You thought this was a walking stick?" He cackled. "I catch them coming each time-godforsaken Sacrosanct spies. They can change their skins, you know, I've witnessed it before. They can change the color of their face and length of their hair in an instant. But they cannot change their degenerate culture, and their revolting lack of true noble civilization."

Now, does anybody here know what fish are in that river?"

"I do, my liege!" The seasoned captain stood up. "Darthfinn, the Rampler, and the Toadfish, though the toadfish is technically a crustacean." He smiled moronically and looked around to boast his greatest life achievement. "My father was an angler in the lakes."

For the first time since she first saw him, the Emperor smiled, quite deviously. "That's right. This one must be one of us, unlike that sorry dead piece of shit over there. Now you have a strong knowledge of 'history', but what of your prowess in battle?"

"Better than almost any man living, my liege." *Somehow I doubt that.* He took a great war axe from behind his back. "Allow me to prove my skills to you, firsthand."

"Go on then. Prove it." He motioned to the tallest one of his men. He took off his helm, revealing the rugged face of a middle-aged man, with choppy white hair and a scar that took out one of his eyes, leaving a black hole. He held a crystal axe and his armor was so shiny Karina could almost see a perfect reflection of herself in its shoulder blades. "This is Sir William Lionhart!"

"My liege, that's William." The man pointed to one of the guards. "My name is Sir Oakmont—"

“Shut the hell up.” The king’s voice was stern. “This warrior, whose name is not important, is a tried and tested veteran. He is famous for his valor at the Ambush of Ashrend and the Defence of Castle Umbara. He’s cut down over a hundred men, suffering only one wound to his eye throughout.”

I can beat him, but let’s see how the captain fares first. “My liege,” she said, “we would love to prove our skill in battle with this renowned warrior.” She gazed at the captain. “How about the most seasoned of us start? Lest we give off a bad impression.”

The captain stammered, then collected himself. “My liege, allow me to duel your warrior!”

“Alright, alright, alright.” The king had grown tired and bored. “Old one, you go first. Fail to defeat him in solo combat, and you will be disqualified from the position.”

“As you command, my liege.” The older captain walked up to Sir Oakmont and swung his axe at the warrior’s head. The warrior ducked under it, and kicked the captain so hard he flung across the room. A huge thud was heard as he bounced off the wall and landed on the ground, and he did not get up.

“Oh. I had such high hopes.” The Emperor said sarcastically. “*Disqualified!*” Another blast of darkness came out from the king’s stick, and the captain joined the scholar as a black portrait on the wall. His ashes didn’t even make a pile, and dispersed randomly across the floor.

Oh gods. He’s going to kill everyone except the winner.

The warrior laughed, sadistically and cruelly, and pointed at the shadow on the wall. The king began cackling with him. “He didn’t even get to swing more than once!”

“Fret not- I will be swinging plenty.” The Musketeer moved in on Oakmont, swinging rapidly and ferociously. The first caught the warrior offguard, the second almost made him stagger to his feet, but the third he saw coming, and he deflected it with one blow before quickly giving another swing, dehanding the challenger. The Musketeer screamed in shame and pain. “No!” he yelled, then fell to his knees, the blood dripping from his handless sockets onto the marble floor.

“He thought he had a chance.” The warrior called out to the king. “He got kind of close.”

“So close.” Karrow jeered. “Too bad.” Then, predictably, a flash of darkness later and the kneeling soldier’s last moments were now a token on the wall, a sizable pile of ashes lay where he once knelt. “Now you, go.” The Emperor motioned to her. “I hope he doesn’t hit your pretty face.” He sneered before turning around to his guards. “What the hell am I going to do if they all lose. I guess we could find another batch.”

“We already did that twice, my liege.” One of his men said.

“We did? When?” He coughed and some glowing elixir juice came out. “Well, third time’s the charm, as they say.”

She began to walk towards the warrior. He looked at her deviously and impatiently, licking his gross lips as she approached. She feigned a trip over the dead captain’s puny little sword, and fell right at the ashes, letting out a scared yelp as she did so. The whole room erupted with laughter, and she quietly grabbed a small handful of the ashes with her left hand as she shamefully got up. “If you give up now, I’ll let you serve as my maiden!” Karrow cried out.

She approached slowly, pretending to shake and jitter as she did so. “Let’s get this over with.” The warrior said as he ran up to her and swung. She used her right hand to block the swing with her shortsword, but he was clearly much greater in strength, and pushed her weapon down as the sword began to reach her shoulder. She used her free left hand to throw the ashes in his eyes– he yelped and staggered backwards, and lowered his blade momentarily. In a flash, she lunged on him and began to jab her dagger in his head.

“Die. Die DIE!” She yelled as she stabbed him in the head over and over, like a knife into a watermelon it tore fast through the crust and even faster through the mushy red insides. Splashes of blood splattered over her and her clothes as she relentlessly dug into him, tragically soiling her pretty corset. She knew he was dead, and the more she stabbed the more disgusted she felt, but the king wanted a show, and she would give him one. The room fell silent by her tenth stab, and after the fifteenth, she finally threw her dagger to the side and turned to face the king, and curtsied.

“My liege.” She said, saltily.

At first, the king's face was one of shock, but it quickly turned to one of pure bliss and childlike excitement. "Oh my gods- that was perfect. Did you see that? A dozen battles he said? I suppose that's why they say thirteen is unlucky." He snickered, then began to almost choke on his laughter.

Noticing a window of opportunity, the sunken weary man grabbed his knife and lunged at the king, managing to get inches away before his guards could react. The steel in his hands got very close to the Emperor's stomach.

She wondered for a split second if it would have been a good thing– the Emperor's madness would drive the Wythen to defeat, surely she knew that. But the Emperor had two sons, one a wrathful narcissist, the other a glutton and drunk, and they were not surrounded by the well studied minds Karrow was. Either way, Oberath would never know.

Karina often impressed herself with her gunplay, but this time she outdid herself. In a room with a dozen guards, Karina got him first, she swung the musket around her shoulder before anyone reacted and took a quick shot. It was bold– if she missed and hit Karrow, ending up as a shadow or a head on a stick would be the lucky outcome. *Fortune favors the bold*, she told herself in relief as the hall erupted in applause and respect. The hulking man's head had a massive window in it, and all his muscle and meat now lay still. Even in his death, his eyes hated.

"Thought you could best me, did you!" The Emperor cheered as if he did anything. "Foolish coward." He kicked the man's head in the window, and his boot got stuck in it for a moment before he had to pull it out, as if it was stuck in mud, making a gross splotching sound. The king turned to Karina. "It appears we have a selection! A talented warrior and my savior." He walked towards her. "A woman too, eh? Well, it's important to keep... *an open-mind!*" He gestured to the dead warrior's corpse, whose head was ripped open.

She didn't find it funny, but cackled extra hard. "Open mind! That's a good one, my liege. I would be honored to kill just like that again in his majesty's service."

"Tell me about yourself, then, girl."

It's my lady. She clicked her dress shoes and smiled. "I am Lady Karina Kenning, daughter of the former Grand Admiral and sister of Castellan of the Render. I have never placed under first rank in any of my courses, I have mastered four trades, including Gunsmithery, Brewing, Spelunking, and Leathworking. I put down four rebellions, and won two skirmishes against Commonwealth forces in the Render and the Shoals." She made her voice as sweet and cheery as she could. "*The Arcane Archer*, they call me."

The Emperor smiled as men marched in with a table in and a map, their boots storming on the ground with echoes. "I hear your enemies call you something else. *Limbthinner*. I don't blame you, sieges are far more effective than fighting in the field, though the songs about them don't sound as good." She watched as they placed the pieces on the Render, run by the savage Chasseur, where all the dead go to die again as mushrooms. The red lands were brutish, with rapid rivers running through the body of it like veins. The *Sickle*, a massive inlet of ocean water that was shaped as such, hung around Castle Ashrend ready to take it down in a swing. The swing came in the *First Royal Regiment's* naval fleet that was storming the stronghold at this very moment. She was not afraid, her brother Percius would throw them back into the sea soon enough.

Castle Ashrend itself was the Wychen's purple. *Purple*. If the Chasseur were red and vicious and the Sacrosanct blue and sophisticated, it only made sense that the Wychen would be the best of both. The Fissures were a great amethyst carpet on the board— riddled with giant cliffs and ravines— that indelicately rolled out onto the Render and the green forested Glades.

The Wychen Empire then tried to take the King by surprise once by piercing through the Glades, getting up to a hundred relays from the Meadows before they were stopped by the forest Rangers and King Maverick's Lumiknights, who was still a prince back then. The King's Meadows were cobalt blue and unbesmirched, fitting for their pretty castles and shiny armor— Karina dreamed of jumping up those floating islands and torching their precious plains and pastures herself.

So many nails, yet the coffin could not stay closed. Every time the Wychen got close to stepping foot on the Meadows, the King's homeland, they were thwarted. The Crown had too much space and too much meat with their three colonies and their three million colonized people. They grew smarter too– Artemis, or the *King's Tiger*, and her Vanchist Legion had been chasing their best armies across the map, retaking the King's lands as she went.

“Case Green!” Karrow announced while licking his lips. “We’ve tried everything, from pushing through the trees to raiding the shores– we hold four of the five Core Castles, and for what? The King's colonies still stand, the Meadows are untouched, and our gains are stalling. We need to move fast before we are unable to deal with our debts– the war machine needs feeding! We grow, our technology grows, yet we can't sustain this growth without conquest!”

“Of course my liege. What are you proposing?”

“My dear Lorynce and commander Ralf are facing Artemis and Maverick in the Northern Render, right above the Redstone Bridge. They command the two strongest armies Oberath has ever seen. Two armies, against their three, but they are weak and exhausted and we have steel and scorpions. Once my son prevails against the King and his tiger he and Ralf will head down over the bridge to destroy the invaders of Castle Ashrend.”

Only a fool would be so certain. There's always some sort of trick. She'd studied Artemis extensively– her ambush tactics, ballista formations, and distributed corps system– they say she hand picks her units from the best outfits across all four of the Kingdom's territories. With her and Maverick's pegasus riders by his side, Lorynce ought to tread carefully. “And after that?” She asked.

“The Crown will have no choice but to dedicate more men to the Render to offset their losses. This means they'll withdraw their support to the Glades in the East, and their defenses will be weakened! We will strike from there!” His fist slammed into the war table, making a huge thud.

She smiled. “What is my role in all this, my liege?” Her eyes sparkled in the purple candlelights, as if she didn't already know. The scented lavender almost dispelled the Emperor's nasty aroma.

“Commander Thragde is dead. Grand Ranger Marand put an arrow in his socket. Maybe you’ll have better luck— women are smaller after all. We hand control of his Scorpion Legion to you, you will assume his role to take advantage of the chaos in the Render and cut through the Glades while the royals are distracted. Then we’ll pincer through Maverick’s Meadows on both sides. They’ll collapse like a house of cards.” He smiled. “I can’t wait to make use of those fields. A waste of land, filled with fields and pastures, it could use some proper industry. I trust that this is a responsibility you can handle?”

“Of course my liege. Which sectors of the Glades do you need conquered for this operation?”

“All of them.”

All of them? That’s his ‘grand strategy’? “As you wish, my liege.” She bowed.

“A carriage is scheduled for you, Commander Kenning.” One of the guards reported.
Commander Kenning. That gave Karina a level of joy she had not felt in a while. “It’ll take you just South of Castle Greenhouse, along with the Castellan of the Glades.”

“Gareth. That nasally scholar.” The Emperor scoffed. “Take him with you, *girl*. I’m done scolding him for the day.” *I liked Commander Kenning a lot more than “girl”.*

“Do be wary, our spies report King Maverick plans to send Prince Arryk to the Glades to bolster their defenses.”

“Arryk the Coward wants to join the fun? Let’s oblige him.” Karrow coughed and gagged before clearing his throat. “Meet my fat son Malkan by the ravine gates, he will bring you up to speed. After which, you will bring Marand’s Rangers to heel, and the Coward Arryk too if he doesn’t run away first.” He laughed maniacally. “Oh my god! I can’t wait to hang Maverick’s head in these halls! WHO CAN STOP ME!?” He held out his arms in a shower of enthusiastic applause surrounded by ashes, shadows, dead men.

She applauded with glee, almost jumping up and down with joy, though something unnerved her in the back of her mind. Was it Ashrend? And Percius? *No. They won’t even get close. Just like Oakmont didn’t with me. We’re the Kennings.*

Percius Kenning I

– *Castellan of the Render* | *Oberath* –

“He killed them in their sleep?” Percius sounded appalled as the keys jingled in his hands. They were like the air around them— cold and wet. *A cowardly action*. He would never say it out loud, but he wished he could. “Nasty business. I wonder what could drive a man to do that.”

“I’d expect more from Karrow’s own boy.” Orellius admitted, the two of them stepped in small puddles as they heard rats scurry along the dungeon halls. *When I run this place, there won’t be puddles nor rats*. “Thank the gods Lorynce is the heir.”

He stepped into the dungeons, built centuries ago by the Chasseur, where they would throw poachers in the cells and let them die of thirst or hang them in the courtyard. The bricks were built from the black clay on the shores near the trident and laid down by the Hunter Lord’s slaves, which back then were mostly the King’s captured Lumiknights. *How things have changed*, Percius chuckled to himself. A droplet from the mossy ceiling above fell onto his long stringy hair as he pointed his finger and began counting the cells on the left.

One. There was a starving man, must have been in his middle ages but looked like an old crone. Limbs were paper, all thin and ghost white. *Two*. The waft of shit and vomit was heavy in the air and punched Percius in the stomach. The girl sat sobbing in the corner, her twisted hair was so long it covered a quarter of the cell. Percius’ stomach kept twisting and churning. *What did these people do?* *Three*. The man just stared.

Percius tried not to notice their belongings, their clothes, the color of any of their eyes. War was war but that didn’t mean he had to enjoy having it burned in his mind. *Four*. She was way more well fed and kept, meat on her bones and color to her skin. Like the other forest dwellers, her skin had sparkles, her hair a tint of green, and her eyes were tall and large. “Are you the painter?”

“Don’t you mean *a* painter?” She asked with no respect.

“I need your help.” He clicked the lock and opened the door. She hardly turned to look at him, staring blankly at the wall, twirling her minty hair with one hand.

“Fine. Only because you won’t feed me real food if I say no, right?” She spat at him.

“I was a prisoner of war once. I didn’t get ‘real food’, only sawdust mixed with a bit of stems and leaves and a tiny *tiny* pinch of flour. But they called it bread– they being *your* people, the same ones who killed my father.” Percius surprised himself with how steady his voice was, in the past when he would talk about such things his fists would turn to steel. “I’m not going to hurt you, but you ought to be more grateful. Look to the people on your left and right. You could look like them.”

She sneered at him. “Only because *he* hasn’t come down yet.” He felt something weird in his stomach.

“That crazy son of a bitch.” Orellius complained.

Whatever he was doing in these cells, Percius wanted to know nothing and have no part. “It’ll be alright. If you help me, I can protect you.”

“You *can*’t.” She cried out like a wounded animal. “He does what he wants with all of us. If I couldn’t paint I’d be spider food, and that’s if I was lucky.”

“But you can paint. And I need *the* painter.”

“Why do you say *the* painter? Wouldn’t any painter do?” He didn’t answer, only gently lifted her up by the arm. He felt poor– she was about his little sister’s age. She groaned as he lifted her up and the three of them began to walk. “Is painting some sort of impossible craft nowadays? None of you can paint? I’ll teach you, how’s that? Then you can just kill me and be done with it. What’s that saying– give a man a deer he feeds for a day, teach him how to hunt and he feeds for a...”

Her voice faded to the background as Percius guided her through the halls. It wasn't any painter they needed, nor one with great imagination or experience. This girl had some sort of talent— a steady hand that allowed her to draw with the uniform precision and speed of a machine. Of course, they had machines for this, but not here, they were put together thousands of relays away. The uniformity was critical, more than the eye for color or the taste for expression. "I'm not just some nobody here, I can change things." He finally explained to her, though he felt it was partially just out of guilt. "I'll be the head of the garrison here, in charge of defense, repairs, maintenance, construction..." A spit ball slammed into his eye as he spoke, cutting him off.

"Bastard! You run this chamber of horrors? I may suffer for all my life but you'll suffer for eternity after you die— sometime soon I hope!"

"I can take out her tongue if you wish." Orellius offered as he unsheathed a silver dagger from his waistband.

"No— no! Absolutely not. Not one more word from either of you." He snarled and tugged her along, less gently this time. He spoke directly to the girl. "I understand your anger, but I'm following my sworn duty to my people by protecting what is now my fortress. There is more to this stronghold than war. This place will be needed to hunt, to facilitate trade, to hold criminals. I'm not just a soldier, I'm a mason, a smith, a builder,—"

"A bastard, a fat bastard with a fat nose and two chins." She complained. *Did I have too much supper last night?* "Tell yourself whatever you want." She said, "Where will you make me put you? A tavern? A volcano? A bridge? A palace? You Wychen love dancing in your palaces. I hate painting palaces by the way, not that any of you care."

"You'll see when we get there." Orellius explained. They climbed a tower of stairs from the dungeon, each step polished and sleek black, the torches made from bone. When they summited the steps the full view from the parapets of Ashrend brought the full prowess of the stronghold in view— centuries of history told through the various facilities in all corners of his eye. The three were running now, passing by sprinting soldiers all the while, some of whom carried wounded.

Bone and blood, and ash and clay. The architecture held the Chasseur symbols well, from the walls down to the decorations. In the courtyard were many tanning stands and fat renderers. In times of peace, men would be walking by with buckets full of melted fat and buckets of glands and meats. The meats would be cut piece by piece from the monsters in the very butcher halls underneath their boots where men would hack chunks of meat and talons off bones with massive blades.

Those were in times of peace. The massive fireworks and fireballs and flares launched from the Commonwealth ships below looked like shadows of the sun in the air as they hurled themselves fruitlessly at the Stronghold walls. The sun and its followers all kissed the already blood red sky, which had been tainted by the dust-off of all the minerals within the black clay all over the Render. *Doomed by the goddess*, Wychen and Sacrosanct often said. Percius had to squint as he ran, he could hear the valiant Musketeers fire off the parapets into the crowds of unwelcome visitors below while they reached the next tower, Percius almost slamming his body into the door to let them into cover. The girl and his comrade exhaled in relief. He was thankful to be in the second line of walls and not the third, for he heard Bladeslingers were already coming over the outermost line.

Percius grabbed a torch that glew amethyst and ushered them to follow him down the stairs, going so fast down his feet were close to flying as he skipped down. The ground rumbled and boomed still, and the sounds of yelling and clamoring echoed through every hall. This was the third time the royal regiment attempted to retake the stronghold, and each time was poorer than the last. *No inventive strategy, no tricks up their sleeves, this is what makes us Wychen and them... them.*

“Can you really make a painting in under five minutes? With no mistakes, perfect straight lines, the like?” Orellius asked. She uncomfortably nodded. “We’ll see for ourselves, and if your talents prove as useful as I keep hearing, then we can offer you some better amnesty, conditions, and maybe a paid position here at Ashrend if the assimilation protocols get implemented.”

“Fuck all that. I want to see my family. Don’t tempt me with consolation prizes.”

“Where does your family live?”

“In god’s clouds next to the pearly gates.” She looked at Percius’ musket. “Can I be accommodated?” Percius wasn’t amused. “It’s fine, you two will bore me to death anyway.” The moss grew thinner and the air grew dryer. They emerged from the dungeon halls and into a polished stone corridor where half a dozen Musketeers marched down with haste in their glowing purple crystal shells, and they were followed by an alchemist sprinting with three massive spiders on leashes, each more hairy and gnarly than the last.

“Musketeers, remarkable aren’t they? Equally adept with melee as with gunplay. I heard that muskets have almost completely replaced bows, not just for warfare, but also for hunting.” Percius said.

“Not where I’m from, they don’t.” She spat. “You people need handicaps for everything, can’t shoot a bow, can’t paint, can’t show manners to a woman either. The thought of you baboons running throughout our woods and putting metal balls into our animals disgusts me.”

“Would it be that much better if we used big wooden sticks instead?” Orellius laughed, his big beard catching some of the spit as he did so.

“Here we are,” Percius declared. They stood among a three way intersection, the left pointed to a trophy room where the heads of the greatest behemoths in the Render lay from across dozens of generations, to right the studies and anatomy of all sorts of beasts across Oberath. Percius stepped forward, where a big purple brick wall with a massive silver moon lay in front of them, he pressed hard against it and it opened. The halls were silver and white, marble and gold. Paintings hung everywhere, of forests full of critters, of waterfalls and rivers, of animals and man, of happy feasts and sorrow endings. One had a prince in shining armor and no face, one of a witch stirring a cauldron of cold green goo, her hat hovering over her face, one had a river where a reaper rowed using the stick of a scythe as an oar. They were large and small, green, blue and gray and red. “Fetch the Arachinist. The largest, most vicious venomous ones we can find.” It was more about the psychological aspect than anything, nobody could ever suspect such a thing. A morbid part of him wanted to see their faces when it happened, but he shoved that thought deep down.

“Choosing which one?” A sneering voice followed by a chuckle sounded out behind him. Percius said the quickest prayer of his life before turning around to greet the, apparently, three of his new visitors. The Artificer stood out first, the man was a foster brother among Karrow’s two boys where the mad cunt Lorynce had essentially adopted him as his little partner in crime. Lorynce allegedly found him face down in the snow while he and Malkan had been mountaineering, and afterwards they nursed him back from the brink of death, unfortunately. He had never seen his eye before, only heard the tales, but there it was, eaten from his head by frostbite, and had now become a massive white orb, like a snowball. The rest of his face on that side was cracked black, but the right of his was fair and ghostly, and he had half medium long silver hair carelessly dropping over the side of his head. Besides him was his infamous enthusiastic assistant, a girl named *Bellacca*, she had gorgeous long silver hair and purple eyes, along with her smooth gray skin. Her ears were long and slanted and carried a huge amount of different jewels. A big metal boiler laid strapped to her back, for what purpose Percius did not know. He heard she was the Artificer’s lover, but he really doubted someone would make love to that creature. The third was Lorynce himself, standing to the Artificer’s left, a handsome man in his mid twenties, he had jagged teeth and big slanted eyes, along with a perfect middle part. He was the tallest in the room, and had the best clothes by far– a purple embroidered tunic with dragons on the front– but that was to be expected for the heir of the empire. “It doesn’t matter which one.” The Artificer continued, hissing like a snake. “They won’t even take a second look. Who would?”

Percius bowed to the heir. “My prince, I’m pleased to make your acquaintance. I’m–”

“I know who you are.” Lorynce dismissed him. “Castellan of the Render, why would you want to oversee such a godforsaken place, so full of beasts and red horror? Why not the beautiful shores of the Brynnic, or the idyllic trees of the Terra, or better yet why not at our beautiful home itself? The Emperor was quite fond of Lord Kenning, if I do recall.”

The most godforsaken part of this place is to your right. “My place is needed where it matters most, on the battlefield. And where you see beasts and horrors, I see meat that feeds thousands, bones that can be made into weapons and tools and glue and fertilizer, fat that can be turned to fuel, clay that can be turned to brick. This place stands among the greatest beasts Oberath has seen for a thousand years, a hundred hunters could be surrounded by ten thousand of the Render’s most ferocious and pick them off one by one behind these walls, turning them into supper in the mealhalls and goods in the market without a single one making it inside. The Commonwealth think that their attack will not be repelled, as if they have the strength of ten thousand beasts! And we have more than a hundred hunters— two thousand Musketeers armed and strong, not to mention the war machines and monsters we have at our disposal.” Percius fell to one knee in front of the prince. “My prince, I am your man. I will destroy the attackers alongside you, and, when the Commonwealth is toppled and you rule Oberath as the new Shade Emperor, I will run your Render for you, turning what you see as a backwater alley for savages into a prosperous state, shipping goods to the states across the world!”

“New Shade Emperor?” The prince glared, his eyes grew bigger and angrier, and his hand hopped to the hilt of his hammer, a massive anvil on a stick, with obsidian skin and amethyst jewels near its head. “Are you insinuating that his liege might find his end soon? That would be treason, I believe.”

“My liege,” Orellius begged. “He did not mean as such. He was only pointing out, that, well as time goes, old men tend to—”

“It’s alright.” Percius called his man down, and spoke to the liege himself. “I meant no offense to my prince. Honest. Like I said— I’m *your* man.” He puffed up his chest and stood tall. The sound of his breathing got loud.

The three of them began to snicker. “Don’t toy with the boy.” Bellacca laughed. “He’s about to wet himself.”

“Rise, *friend*.” Lorynce laughed. Percius staggered awkwardly to his feet and grabbed his glove, before he was rapidly hoisted up like a sailor with his flag. “The Wythen could always use more men with real grit like you. Not like these other fools, they grovel at my feet. You grovel at my feet too. Do you know why I’m not bothered by you like I am with the fools? ‘I’m your man.’” He began to holler, the Bellacca did as well, even the painter girl. The Artificer only looked at him creepily with his one good eye. “All the others,” Lorynce continued. “They just kiss my ass. You claim you are my man. That’s your vote of confidence. What I hear is that you can run the Render right? One day, my father put a boy raised by the father of a pasturage in charge of the Brynnic. He had wits and charisma, and a certain amount of enthusiasm for conquest we love to see! But, the Brynnic is not his way. My father made a mistake.” Percius opened his mouth to say something but Lorynce shushed him. “No, if you spoke anything about what I just said I’d have to cut out your tongue. The pasturage boy ended up dying in a shipwreck from a seastorm he didn’t foresee. He could govern and kill and be dutiful but we killed him with our philosophical negligence. My brothers can be like my father, he may have put you here but you have yet to earn my vote of confidence. So, will you run my Render for me?”

“I’ll run it.” Percius pledged enthusiastically. “I’ll run the fuck out of it.” Lorynce stared at him for a moment.

“Why should I believe you?” He said slowly and equally skeptical as he was curious.

Percius stood up straight and cleared his throat. “Onwards, you have this!” The Painter said cruelly.

“When I arrived here, the boys were using their horns to call the beasts in, sending out decoys to lure them into their trap. They had stripped the old ballistas with greater shinier more modern ones that would fire five times as fast and ten times as accurately. They sounded their horns and sent out decoys, bringing hundreds of the beasts around the local area. Before the new turrets, it would take a hundred good bladeslingers, and a hundred garrison units as well. The boys celebrated, they shipped all their massive chunks of meat back for the Wythen people, bringing back all the gold in return. They gorged on sweets and ale, not knowing the travesty they caused.”

“Travesty?”

“They hunted four species down to extinction. Another nineteen almost as near. Each had a unique variety of bone, of tusk, of meat flavor, of value to us. We will never get to use the four, and not the nineteen for some time. If I had arrived a week later, we would most likely have lost most of the beast variety save the spawns that sell for coppers compared to the others.”

Lorynce glared at him. “Who caused this outrage?”

“A green spoiled boy named Marvin. Runs a crew of his minions as they drink and shoot their way out of everything.”

“Hang him.”

“I already had him demoted, sir—” He looked into Lorynce’s eyes. They craved. Percius remembered Marvin’s snobby face calling him weak for having a bit of foresight. *Fool*. He thought of having the royal family at court, with a crowned Lorynce feasting at his tables. The meat is collected and fat is churned, but the beasts are sustained and they grow and can foster, in a new cycle of land of hunting that combines the technological might of the Wychen and the martial talent of the Chasseur. A new way of life for them all. But for Marvin? Percius affirmed his stance. “Consider it done.” He nodded to Orellius to have it done. He turned to look at the Artificer. *Would he fit in this new way?*

The Artificer would hunt every species to extinction, save two, and then keep them all in a labyrinth and call himself the new god of beasts. Percius’ new way of running things won’t have any room for a man like that. He called out to the Arachinist. “Fetch webbed spiders. Not Venomous ones.”

The monster smiled. “I am pleased you are among us.”

I wish I could say the same.

Lorynce continued as he walked off. “I’ll trust you can hold this fortress for me. I must depart, my invasion force is leaving.”

“Your invading force? We are being invaded right now?”

“I know, I’m deeply sorry. But, we must depart for a naval invasion of the Redstone Bridge. Me and my Amphibious Raiders will take the bank, attack from behind, then come down the bridge and relieve the invaders.” *Smart man.*

“I can guide you to the underwater boats. They are experimental, I’ll warn you.”

He did not turn his head to respond. “I have faith in the engineers. Farewell, *friend*.”

Sable Lorne I

– Constable | Amberwick –

Don't cheer so loud, she thought to herself as the townspeople roared, the men, the women, and of course the children, who always cheered the hardest. *They can always hear*. Perhaps almost a decade of peace had made people complacent, or even comfortable. It was a slow process– the guards slowly began to knock off more often, parents stopped teaching their children how to fight, men spending their nights in saloons instead of the workshops and target ranges.

Sable's guard would never be let down, not again. The three of them rode in unison through the settlement square, where a small withered statue of a bearded man holding books and a hammer was hailed by lanes of maple auburn leaves and hickory wood. Sable's white horse, Dyelabon, whinnied and neighed as her hooves stomped on crumpled leaves and rotten apples, which made squishes as dying cries with prints left in the ground to mark their graves. The prints would never stay for long however, the winds of change would come in, whether as a light breeze or a gust or a hurricane, and it would move the dirt back in its place. Maybe in a day, maybe in a hundred. *The wind never loses. Change is all there is*. The Morric had been fools to try and challenge their very way of life. Nomadic people, that's what they were, people of the wind, their customs and weapons had always agreed. To settle in forts and castles as if the winds couldn't make wood stone and steel tumble down... *Fools*. She was one of the fools of course, she thought it would be good to stop running, stop riding, stop the searches and the hunts and the roams, start living under the same roof with family every day. They promised her so and she believed them, she was young and wanted an escape from the hardship. Now her escape was the hardship.

The cheers began to die down as they came from the impasse of the valleys, where only a few families stood as fishermen and hunters who lay traps built from sticks in the rivers and woods. They were unarmed, for Windlocks would paint a rabbit onto the earth and dissolve a fish into the water in which it swam, so more delicate methods would be used.

Red leaves fell in Sable's hair, stuck to her auburn hair she swatted violently to get them off as they clung to her with all their might. The final cheers died out as they cleared the valley. *Home, for now.* Not for long. Only once did they ride out from the earshot of the villagers were they finally allowed to speak, and predictably, the first one was Jayce, who rode to her left on his chestnut coated horse, a fair touch darker than his copper hair. "I reckon we'll run into the shades tonight. We should have brought Cassia instead of this scholar." He was trying to make her mad, and he would succeed. He liked her, she could tell. Did she like him back? *Likely not.*

The "scholar" threw an acorn that she tucked into her saddlebag at his head. She was a skinny girl with big pretty doe eyes, and wore a beautiful windguard, a layered tangle of colorful fabrics to keep the wind and all it carried away from the skin. The dyework on her windguard was impressive, as most things Samara did, red from berries and cream from terracotta and brown from bark, elegantly layered over her neck, lush soft and gently bouncing as they rode. She was gorgeous the way Sable wished she were when she was young. Sable's features were rough where hers were soft, eyes sharp where hers were sweet with long lashes, hair loose and tangled where hers was long and shiny, her frame lean and built where hers was willowy. That was then— now, her face had grown hollower, her cheeks wider, her eyes more sunken, her hair longer and in more auburn tussles. Her freckles began to blend in a bit more with her skin. In her youth, she would look at a girl like Samara and feel an overbearing wave of envy.

Jayce would try to win her over, Sable knew, but could he try harder? Wearing a thrown together windguard with mismatched colors, ugly coarse tough fabrics flopping in his face in the wind, he looked a jester and her a princess. "Say that again, I'll have your head." She spoke with so much angst. Sable was not surprised, Jayce mentioned that "loathsome" Cassia, a good shooter and Hanny's archenemy for a reason that largely depended on her attitude that day.

"Alright, alright. Don't throw those things, it's impolite. Not to mention a waste of food. Throw it slower so I can catch them at least."

Crunch crunch. She munched on the acorns. "The ants will eat them. That's not a waste. You catching them is a waste." *Are these two flirting? In front of me?* Love was in the air— Sable could not see it but when the gusts blew hard she could feel it caress her cheeks and bring water to her eyes. She almost even caught her bitter self smiling. There was never a good day to ride out not knowing if you would return, but if there was, today was it. The feel of cool breeze, the smell of maple sap and oak resin, the sound of song birds singing, though the singing songbirds struggled against the sound of the two lovebirds. The sun set on top of the hills in the distance, its orange beams shooting through the gaps in the trees and striking Sable's body all over. *The moon will be on us soon.* Dusk was settling. They rode past rivers and lakes and squirrels and mountains. The tales say the roads were made centuries ago by the Expeditionaries, a group of adventurers set on mapping all of Amberwick out and connecting it corner to corner. It was those tales that made Sable want to wear the Constables star since she was a girl. She placed a chunk of wild carrot in Dyelabon's massive jaws, patting her neck all as she did so. The sun was lower now, almost gone, and everything began to blacken.

"Here. Dismount. Locks loaded." *Click, click.* She rolled her eyes. *Of course I had to remind them.* Sable carefully tied Dyelabon's hitch around a tree three times. "We walk on foot, and we are quiet. Find bushes or trees or rocks. If they find you before we're ready, I can't save you, remember that." Sable carried a small metal box while the two ran to a batch of trees to kiss in behind her back. She ran to one that had that copper shade to it and slammed a small pointy carved stone dagger in its bark where it poured out a putrid smell like a pot of rot. *Perfect.*

She climbed the large tree with the grace and speed of a chipmunk. In her younger years, before she tried being a mother, she would scale cliff faces and rocks all the time, much to her late parents' dismay. At the tip of the tree the winds began to howl at her, and slam into the tree, rocking the entire thing like a raft in the white waters. The tree almost flung her off but her grip was iron. She placed the metal box at the top before she dug the dagger into the side, and stamped her toes against the trunk as the dagger cut to the ground. A big thud rang out as she landed in a clutter of flying leaves, and as the leaves fell to the floor Sable hastily slammed the other box into the trunk and ran to the trees, grabbing on to the first sturdy branch she found. *They always forget to look up.* When the flying leaves fell to the ground, the Shades had arrived.

It takes some experience to know exactly when , but the wind gets *colder* and *dry*, like there's ice and sand in the air– it scratches the skin and makes the vision blurry. It feels off, the rest of the air is always so warm and humid, it's as if mother nature herself ran in horror when they arrived. Sable always felt she was one with nature, but she was not a mother, not anymore. She would not fail on both counts, and when shades walked the trees wailed and the leaves turned to ash. She did not run in horror, not when the shades grew close and their darkness closer, not when they hovered under the branch she desperately clung onto, her strong arm growing weaker and the weaker branch breaking off. A splinter or two fell onto the shades. They had long legs where they stomped, and looked like walking pools of tar, with demonic rainbows coursing through its dark body. Its eyes gleamed as it stomped on the ground, the leaves dissolving into ashes as it groomed the grass around it to purple, making a small ring around the monster. She could hear it *sarling*, the wretched creature. The moon was fully upon them now, and the light shone hard on all.

Wind kept blowing as gales and gusts, it grew cold and stale and dry as Sable knew it would, and the metal box at the trunk vacuumed it up before exploding in a small burst of metal shrapnel and splinters, taking the trunk out in one bite. The box up in the leaves sucked up far more air, but it wasn't rigged to blow, only to hold until its thin tin shell broke. The tall brown leaves came down to smack the ground, and the shell shattered into a thousand pieces, blasting wind in each and every direction, shooting rings of gusts like a tornado imploding from the inside, taking out the trees and the bushes in a violent burst. The shades flinched, their big purple lights that were eyes flashed and blinked rapidly in the pain. One of the four didn't even survive the explosion, being reduced to shredded ribbons on the ground.

The brass barrel glided in the wind with her body, she cocked the lever back and slid on the leaves, they formed a small whirlwind in front of her before she shot. There was the high pitched squeak of a hawk, a gorgeous shrill. She couldn't see what it fired, only the leaves getting blown away in a burst, some of them smashed into the ground. There was a purple circle of corrupted grass by the shade, but a massive circle of moving and crushed leaves beelined towards it. The shade took the compressed air and imploded into gibs. A quick flash of light came and died, and left behind scattered pools of still tar. The third took a hit from Jayce, which blew a chunk of it into the sky then from Samara, before dwindling into pieces of tar on the grassy ground. *Food for the worms.* She quickly cranked her bolt four times as the last shade approached her, its body bearing holes where she could see light. The splinters and shrapnel had cut dagger-like wounds through it. With each crank the pump of the windlock worked, and soon she fired into the last shade. In one last shrill like howl and a blast of wind, the monster's legs were shredded into rainbow ribbons, leaving it a crawling mess of arms and a head. The squeaking from the gun was music to her ears. She loved the way the trigger felt on her fingers, the way her calluses ran on the edges of the brass, the way the bolt caused the gears to turn to cause the pump to suck in more air. The creature began to scream out, screeching so loud Sable couldn't wait to end it. It crawled to something, into the forest towards the treeline. "What the hell is it doing?" Jayce cried out before being aggressively shushed by Sable. In the corner of her eye she saw Samara' punch Jayce in the arm and scold him, she couldn't hear her do it, but could see the "arm thing" she did when she wanted to yell at someone. She followed the crawling shade. *I should shoot it. Why haven't I?* Something drew her to it, the curiosity was unbearable. It crawled its way to the woods before it suddenly burst, the pop emitted a flash of light, its rainbow tar body falling over the ground and corrupting the grass it fell on. Among the critters in the bushes and the trees on his sides that lay a sign, though it said nothing. She walked past it and into the woods, where she followed the vague sound of water flowing. She had been around here before— there had not been a river or a lake or a pond at this part of the woods. But there was water. Like a cat, she followed the itch her mind had until she happened upon a stone brick shrine, where water flowed out and onto the mud ground, the blue seeping into the orange leaves. The bricks held small cracks and were uniform in shape, though each

had a slightly different shade. The wind blew, she could feel the water soak the air as a moist gust hit her face and blew her hair behind her ears.

The water glowed blue, a light blue with lighter blue specks bouncing around inside. There were fairies swimming in it, it was clear and pristine enough that Sable wanted to bathe in it. She stopped closer, and in such clear water saw her reflection perfectly. She had the rough edged high cheekbones, furrowed brows, angled eyes, long nest of auburn hair. There were moles and freckles by her cheeks and nose, along with freckles. She didn't even notice the boy's face at first, his freckles aligned almost exactly with hers, his eyes the same rich bold browns, his hair all rich and rustled like hers. She gasped, and it felt like blood stopped reaching her face.

"A boy!" Samara shouted in surprise. Jayce shushed her as a mocking joke and got no response. Samara ran closer. "He must be drowning!" Sable knew somehow that he was doing just fine. She watched motionless as they dragged his faint face and dangling body out of the water. A satchel fell off of his shoulder, where a book fell to the ground. The bubbles danced in the water. Sable felt so faint. Jayce started doing chest compressions. "Breathe into his mouth too Jayce!"

A book? She walked over and held it, the cover was old and made of leather that must have seen a dozen storms and then some. Tattered, deteriorated, yet somehow, still legible. When she opened, she was surprised to see pages in perfect condition, save for the specks of dirt her fingers loosely dropped onto the pages. Her face was already feeling drained, and her fingers felt the same as she carefully flipped through.

Lumiknights of the Sacrosanct

Clad in silver or gold armor, and gemstone swords, the Lumiknights ride legged and winged horses through the lush Meadows. They hold flare blasters, fireworks, flashlanterns, and crossbows.

A winged horse... That was the most ludicrous part that she had read. Men in steel suits used to roam the world, it was said. The boy was holding a relic from some ancient time.

Rangers of the Terra

Donning their green cloaks, netmasks, and wooden bows, they fire arrows from the darkness of the greenery, laced with venom from plants and creatures alike. They hold bugnets, hornet hives, poison darts, and boomerangs.

A hornet hive? Was this a relic, or something from an ancient tribe that passed the map's edges? She never knew hives to be a weapon, only a home for the ants. *Some distant land, or a fairy tale this boy made up.* There could be distant lands, for all she knew, their map's edges were narrow compared to the width of the horizons.

In the North the mountains grew so tall that the wind would blow any man off, in the West the lake stretched far and wide and no one had crossed it without running into the Shades in the water, which were known to take any vessel and crush them in one blow. In the East was just an empty barren wasteland of cracked dry land that stretched beyond anyone had ever travelled, not that there had been any reason to. It was so vast yet so devoid of any life, even seeing an insect or a shrub at the map's edges was rare. *The East.* Had he somehow come from beyond the East? How he could have crossed and summoned a pool where he now lay was unbeknownst to her. The South was riddled with the massive ravines, scars seeping corruption onto the grass floor, with Shades grappling over. *A land beyond, where knights jostled on winged horses...* Sable smiled at the thought. As a child, she would always dream of catching the winds somehow, and fly amongst the birds. *God should have given Dyelabon wings,* she thought. *She is beautiful enough, she deserves them.* Maybe if she found this distant land, they could put a pair on her. She flipped to a random page, where a diagram of a bronze fan lay. The illustrations were faint, rigid, and three dimensional, showing the in depth features of the fans rigid sides, wide base, and flaps. The golden etches were a great many rings, each a different size. *The Flabellum,* the page said, with nothing else. A blast of water shot out, coarse coughing came with it. His chest heaved and thudded against the leaves, smashing them into dust.

"It's working! He's awake!" Jayce chanted.

The boy's eyes opened. They were brown, so chestnut brown. The faintness returned. She remembered how her freckles matched his, like the same stars on the same skies. Her chest felt a pinch, she wanted to cover her face. It was so red, she knew, though it was hard to explain to herself why. She could barely breathe, even with the wind blasting into her throat, her body was scarce for air. She watched him rise gently, as if he had a blanket over him and just had a bad dream. The leaves blew into his auburn hair, they got stuck in the turtles within. Suddenly her legs turned to gel. The leaves flew in the air and eyes were to the sky when her vision went black.